The Danube: Europe's International River

Geography, history and nature

The River at a Glance

The Danube is the second-longest river in Europe, after the Volga. It is about 2,850 kilometres long, and it flows from west to east across the continent, from the mountains of Germany to the Black Sea.

No other river in the world touches as many countries. The Danube flows through or along the borders of ten countries: Germany, Austria, Slovakia, Hungary, Croatia, Serbia, Romania, Bulgaria, Moldova and Ukraine. Its wider drainage basin, the land whose rain and rivers feed it, reaches into nineteen countries, which is more than any other river basin on Earth.

Four national capitals lie on its banks: Vienna in Austria, Bratislava in Slovakia, Budapest in Hungary and Belgrade in Serbia. This is more capital cities than on any other river in the world. Many other important cities also grew up on the Danube, including Novi Sad in Serbia, Ruse in Bulgaria, and Galati, Braila and Tulcea in Romania.

The river is named differently in each language it passes through. It is the Donau in German, the Dunaj in Slovak, the Duna in Hungarian, the Dunav in Serbian and Bulgarian, and the Dunarea in Romanian. The ancient Romans called its upper part the Danuvius and its lower part the Ister.

For thousands of years the Danube has been a highway for trade, a route for armies and a border between empires. Today it is also an important source of electricity, drinking water, fish and tourism.

From the Black Forest to the Black Sea

The Danube begins in the Black Forest in south-western Germany. Two small streams, the Breg and the Brigach, join near the town of Donaueschingen, and from this meeting point the river is officially called the Danube. A traditional spring in the town is often described as the source, though the Breg is the longer of the two streams.

In its upper course the river flows east through Germany past Ulm and Regensburg and enters Austria. It then passes through Vienna and continues to Bratislava in Slovakia. Here it becomes a wide lowland river, dividing into branches and forming large islands.

Further downstream the Danube bends south and flows through Budapest, the capital of Hungary, where bridges link the hilly Buda bank with the flat Pest bank. It then crosses the Great Hungarian Plain and forms part of the border between Croatia and Serbia before reaching Belgrade, where the Sava river flows into it.

After Belgrade the Danube cuts through the Carpathian Mountains in a dramatic gorge called the Iron Gates, which forms the border between Serbia and Romania. This is the narrowest and deepest section of the whole river. Below the gorge the river continues along the border of Romania and Bulgaria across the Wallachian plain.

Near the end of its journey the river turns north and then east through southern Romania. At the city of Tulcea it splits into three main branches, the Chilia, the Sulina and the Sfantu Gheorghe, which spread across a huge marshy delta before reaching the Black Sea.

The Danube in History

For the Roman Empire the Danube was the northern frontier. Roman legions built forts and watchtowers along its banks, and cities such as Vindobona, today's Vienna, and Singidunum, today's Belgrade, began as military camps. The frontier defences are known to historians as the Danube limes.

In the early second century the emperor Trajan led two wars against the kingdom of Dacia, in 101-102 and 105-106 AD, with the aim of conquering the area north of the river, which is now much of Romania. To move his army across the Danube he commissioned the architect Apollodorus of Damascus to build a great stone and timber bridge near the present town of Drobeta-Turnu Severin. It was completed around the year 105.

Trajan's Bridge was an engineering marvel, about a kilometre long, resting on twenty stone piers. It was for a long time the longest bridge known to the ancient world. Parts of the piers were still visible in the river in modern times, and the bridge is shown on Trajan's Column in Rome.

In the Middle Ages the Danube was a border between kingdoms and a route for crusaders and traders. Later it lay between the Habsburg and Ottoman empires, whose armies fought many battles near the river. Cities such as Belgrade and Buda changed hands several times.

In the nineteenth century steamships began to carry passengers and cargo along the river. In 1856 an international commission was created to keep the mouth of the Danube open to shipping, one of the earliest examples of countries cooperating to manage a shared river.

Iron Gates, Canals and the Delta

The Iron Gates gorge was a dangerous place for boats for centuries because of rocks and strong currents. In the twentieth century Romania and Yugoslavia worked together to build a large hydroelectric dam there. The Iron Gates I dam was completed in 1972, and it produces electricity for both countries while also making the river deeper and safer for ships.

Another famous project is the Danube-Black Sea Canal in Romania, opened in 1984. About 64 kilometres long, it links the river at Cernavoda to the port of Constanta on the Black Sea. Ships using the canal avoid the long journey around the delta, which saves several hundred kilometres.

The Danube Delta is where the river meets the sea, and it is one of the best-preserved river deltas in Europe. It covers several thousand square kilometres, most of it in Romania and a smaller part in Ukraine. The landscape is a maze of channels, lakes, reed beds, sandbanks and forests. It is also the largest continuous reed bed in the world.

Every year the river carries sand and mud into the delta, which makes it grow slowly into the sea. Because of its richness and fragile habitats, the Danube Delta was designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1991 and is also protected as a biosphere reserve.

People have lived in the delta for centuries. Fishing villages such as Sulina and Sfantu Gheorghe can be reached only by boat, and many residents still earn their living from fishing, reed cutting and small-scale tourism.

Nature and Culture of the Danube

The Danube Delta is a paradise for birdwatchers. More than 300 species of birds have been recorded there, and millions of birds use the delta as a stopover on their migrations between Europe and Africa. Two kinds of pelican, the great white pelican and the Dalmatian pelican, nest in the delta, together with herons, egrets, cormorants and many others.

The river is home to numerous fish species, including carp, catfish and pike. The most famous are the sturgeons, enormous ancient fish that can live for decades and are valued for their eggs, known as caviar. Several sturgeon species of the Danube are now critically endangered because of overfishing, dams and pollution, and international programmes work to protect them.

Pollution and flooding are serious concerns. The river passes through intensively farmed land and heavy industry, and its countries have cooperated since 1998 through the International Commission for the Protection of the Danube River to improve the quality of its water and reduce the risk of floods.

The Danube has also inspired music, literature and art. The best known musical tribute is the waltz An der schoenen blauen Donau, or The Blue Danube, composed in 1866 by Johann Strauss II. It became the unofficial anthem of Vienna and is still played every New Year in concerts around the world.

Today the Danube is a popular route for river cruises and cycling holidays. A long bicycle path follows the river from Germany through Austria to Hungary and beyond, passing castles, vineyards and old towns. For many visitors, travelling along the Danube is a way to experience the history and variety of Europe in a single trip.